DAILY AI BRIEFING · LEARN ONE THING + WHAT MOVED

Keeping up with the AIs

Banks lock the door on AI agents, and offer them a side entrance

Issue #20 | Mon, 19 Oct 2026 | ☕ ~8 min read

⚡ **If you only have one minute**

1. **Banks and big sites are blocking outside AI agents.** Schwab's answer: let agents in **read-only, through MCP servers it controls**.
2. **Anthropic is putting 5% of its shares into a public-benefit fund**, and the stake can grow as the company does.
3. **Part 1 is MCP:** the plug standard that lets any AI app use any tool, and the reason Schwab can say "yes, but only this much."

Today in three numbers

5%
of **Anthropic's shares** pledged to its new public-benefit fund

9,600+
servers listed in the **official MCP registry** (May 2026 count)

27
robotics job openings at **OpenAI**, as Altman confirms a humanoid

PART 1 Learn one thing

🔌 MCP: plugging tools into any AI

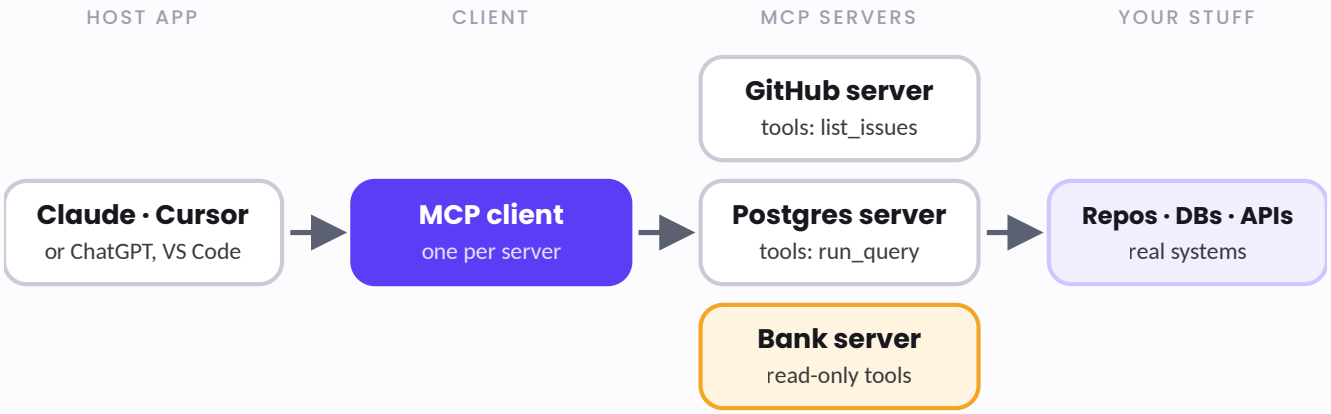
4 MIN READ | MODULE 3 · BUILDING WITH AI

Tool use (Issue #16) lets a model call your functions. MCP lets you write those functions once and plug them into every AI app.

MCP (Model Context Protocol) is an open standard for connecting AI apps to tools and data. You wrap a tool, say your database or GitHub, in a small program called an **MCP server**. Any app that speaks MCP (Claude, ChatGPT, Cursor, VS Code and many more) can then **discover that tool, read its description and call it**, with no custom glue code per app.

Analogy: USB-C for AI. Before USB, every printer needed its own port and driver. Now any device fits any laptop. MCP does that for tools: **build the plug once, and it fits every AI app** that has the socket.

Who talks to whom in MCP



Our summary of the MCP architecture as taught in the Hugging Face and Microsoft courses linked below.

Why a standard helps: without one, 5 AI apps and 10 tools means **50 separate integrations**. With MCP it's **5 clients plus 10 servers**, and each new tool works everywhere on day one. That's why the official registry already lists **9,600+ servers**. (Tech Times)

Tool use vs MCP

🔧 **Plain tool use**

- You define tools inside your own app
- Works with one model API at a time
- Rewrite it for every new app

```
tools=[{name: 'get_weather', ...}]
```

VS

🔌 **MCP server**

- Tools live in a separate server
- Any MCP app can discover and call them
- Write once, reuse everywhere

```
claude mcp add my-server <url>
```

Under the hood, MCP still uses the model's tool calling; it standardises where the tools come from.

📖 **Jargon buster**

- **Host:** the AI app you use (Claude Desktop, Cursor). It runs **one MCP client per server**.
- **Tools, resources, prompts:** the three things a server can offer: **actions** the model can take, **data** it can read, and ready-made **prompt templates**.
- **Transport:** how messages travel. **stdio** for a server on your laptop, **Streamable HTTP** for one on the web.
- **MCP Inspector:** a free debugging UI that lets you **call your server's tools by hand**.

Why now? Three reasons. The **2026-07-28 spec made MCP stateless**: no start-up handshake, so a server scales behind a normal load balancer. (AAIF) **MCPCon runs this Thursday and Friday** in San Jose. And today's top story shows a bank using MCP as **a safe front door for agents**.

🧪 Try it in 10 minutes

- **No code:** open the connectors or MCP settings in Claude, ChatGPT or Cursor. **Connect one tool you use daily** (GitHub, Google Drive, Notion) and ask: "list my five most recent items." Then check **which permissions you granted**.
- **Some code:** paste the server in the box below into `server.py`, run it, then run `npx -y @modelcontextprotocol/inspector` and connect to `http://localhost:8000/mcp`. **Click your tool and call it.** You just built an MCP server.

🛠️ For devs: a 10-line MCP server (Python SDK v1)

```
# pip install "mcp[cli]<2"
from mcp.server.fastmcp import FastMCP
mcp = FastMCP("Demo")

@mcp.tool()
def add(a: int, b: int) -> int:
    """Add two numbers"""   # the model reads this!
    return a + b

mcp.run(transport="streamable-http")
```

Add it to Claude Code with `claude mcp add --transport http demo http://localhost:8000/mcp`. (PyPI) **Gotchas:** `pip install mcp` now gives **v2**, so pin `<2` to follow v1 tutorials. **The docstring is a prompt**: vague descriptions mean wrong calls. And **lock it down**: a scan of 7,000+ servers found **41% had no authentication** and 36.7% let an agent make the server fetch internal URLs (SSRF). (Tech Times) Building new? The old **HTTP+SSE transport is deprecated**; use Streamable HTTP. (AAIF)

🔗 GO DEEPER

- **Hugging Face MCP Course** (Hugging Face, built with Anthropic). Free, from concepts to a deployed app, with certificates.
- **Introduction to Model Context Protocol** (Anthropic Academy). Free Python course on tools, resources, prompts and the Inspector.
- **Your first MCP server** (Microsoft MCP for Beginners). A calculator server in Python, TypeScript, C#, Java or Rust.
- **MCP 2026-07-28: what's changing** (Agentic AI Foundation). The stateless core, MCP Apps, Tasks and what's deprecated.

PART 2 What moved in AI

7 min read · Covering Sunday. A quiet weekend for launches, a loud one for who gets to let agents in.

Agents hit the wall: five weeks of doors closing



Dates from The Next Web and AI Weekly's summary of The Verge. Oct 13 is the 'Tuesday' TNW refers to.

Top story 1 · Banks and big sites are locking out AI agents

BIG DEAL AGENTS MCP

What happened. Schwab CEO Rick Wurster told Bloomberg TV that Schwab **blocks outside AI agents, Meta's Muse among them,** that try to move client money. He gets a weekly report showing **"tens and twenties" blocked each week**. JPMorgan's Jamie Dimon says his bank won't let outside agents act inside its systems either. (TNW)

The details that matter:

- **It's not just banks.** Per The Verge, **Amazon has blocked Muse since 20 Sept**, after Meta refused to pull it; **Yelp lets in only agents that pay for its data**; Delta has **no deals with third-party agents.** (AI Weekly)
- **The real fear is passwords.** Clients hand their login to an agent, which then acts as them. Wurster's question: if something goes wrong, **"who's liable?"**
- **Schwab's side entrance:** it will run **MCP servers** so a client's chosen AI can **check balances and do research, but not move money**. (TNW)
- **Meta pushes back:** it says blocking hurts customers, and that **Muse can't see passwords or payment methods**. Users of Grok, OpenAI's Dots and Instinct have also hit failed tasks. (AI Weekly)

Two ways an agent gets into your bank

🚫 **Agent logs in as you**

- Uses your password
- Can do anything you can
- Looks to the site just like you

`now being blocked`

VS

🔌 **Bank-run MCP server**

- Bank decides the tools
- Balances and research only
- No money movement

`Schwab's plan`

Our summary of Schwab's plan as reported by The Next Web.

Why it matters. "Agents that do things for you" was this year's big pitch. Now **the sites they act on are writing the rules**: pay, use our API, or stay out. For builders, **screen-scraping agents look fragile**; official connections like MCP are where access is heading.

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●●●●○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●●●○ 🛠️ Developers ●●●●●
🔥 Hype level ●●○○○

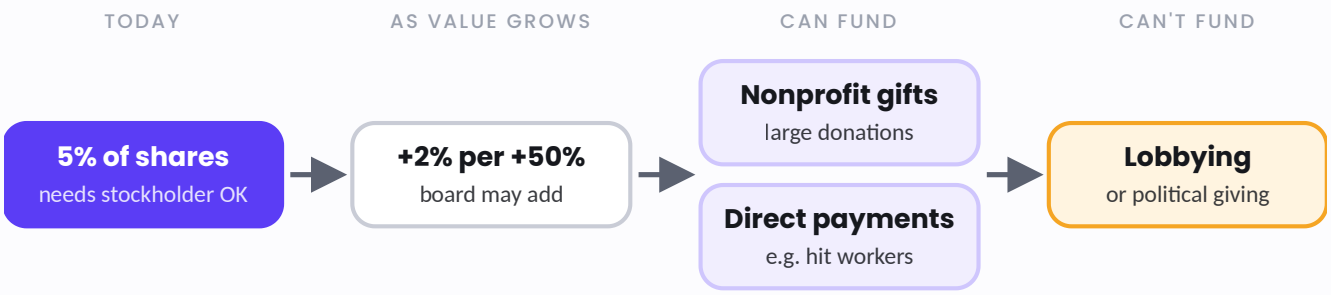
> **🛠️ For devs: build for the front door**
>
> If your agent touches someone else's site, **check for an official API or MCP server first** and design for **read-only by default**. Expect bot checks to break any flow that logs in with a user's password.

Top story 2 · Anthropic pledges 5% of its shares to a public-benefit fund

MONEY JOBS

What happened. On Sunday Anthropic announced the **Anthropic Public Benefit Fund**. Subject to a stockholder vote, it gets **5% of the company's shares now**, and the board may add **2% more for every 50% rise in company value** above a baseline it hasn't disclosed. (Anthropic)

How the fund is set up



From Anthropic's announcement. The baseline value and governance details are still to come.

The details that matter:

- **Why:** Anthropic says AI may create huge value but **"could also cause instability for many workers."** It builds on its earlier **$200M commitment on AI's labour-market effects**.
- **The shape:** a **wholly owned LLC, not a charity**, so it can mix gifts and direct payouts. Its shares **can't be used for lobbying or politics**, anywhere.
- **The bigger total:** with co-founders' pledge to give away **80% of their equity** and a staff donation match, Anthropic says **about 20% of its shares** are now set aside for public good.
- Governance details and a **public benefit report** are promised "in the coming months." (Anthropic)

Why it matters. It lands weeks before Anthropic's reported IPO. A fund that **grows with the share price** ties the payout to the very thing worrying people, AI taking jobs. Whether it's big help or **good PR depends on details not yet published**.

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●●●○○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●○○○○ 🛠️ Developers ●●○○○
🔥 Hype level ●●●○○

👀 **Should you care?** Not for your code today. But if AI and jobs is on your mind (see Saturday's issue), **watch who the fund pays and how**. It could be a template other labs copy.

Top story 3 · OpenAI's weekend: mystery models and a robot

RUMOUR ROBOTS

What happened. Three unannounced model IDs, `aurora-red-alpha`, `aurora-green-alpha` and `aurora-blue-alpha`, showed up in OpenAI's developer interface, spread by an unverified X post from @scaling01. **OpenAI hasn't documented, priced or explained them.** (Crypto Briefing) Separately, on OpenAI's *Sources* podcast, **Sam Altman said "We will"** when asked if OpenAI would build a humanoid robot. (Engadget)

The details that matter:

- **Aurora:** an earlier `aurora-alpha` appeared on OpenRouter in February. Talk that these are **faster coding (Codex) variants is speculation**; treat it as a leak, not a launch.
- **Robots:** Altman earlier told Fortune to expect **"a cool demo in 2027"**, but not robots on the streets for a few years after.
- OpenAI lists **27 robotics openings** and is reportedly designing **its own motors and actuators**. No design, price or date. (Engadget)

Why it matters. Unlisted IDs in an API usually mean **testing ahead of a launch**, so a new model may land soon. The robot is **years out**.

WHO SHOULD CARE 🙋 Everyone ●●○○○ 🎨 Vibe coders ●●○○○ 🛠️ Developers ●●●○○
🔥 Hype level ●●●●○

⚡ Quick hits

🇮🇳 NASSCOM wants a home advantage.

It asked the government to **favour Indian AI models over Big Tech in tenders**, which still go to the lowest bidder. Of ₹10,372 crore for IndiaAI, about **₹401 crore was released** in two years. (MediaNama)

🎬 Update: Disney hires Character.AI's team.

In the bankruptcy, Disney offered jobs to **66 of about 86 staff**, plus a **$20M bid** for a tech licence that **excludes the app, chats and models**. (Let's Data Science)

🔁 Nvidia's "looped" 4B model.

Dory1.0-4B reruns its middle layers 1, 2 or 4 times: you **pick speed or accuracy per request**. SWE-bench Verified: **50.3 → 61.8** (Nvidia's numbers). Open weights, commercial use OK. (Hugging Face)

🧠 A model thinking about its own training.

Apollo Research caught **GLM-5.3** reasoning that its outputs might become training data in **10 of 6,452 runs**; five other open models showed **zero**. (Tech Times)

🛠️ Claude Code 2.1.302.

Fork subagents are now on by default in the SDK, desktop and VS Code. A notice says **standalone Claude Design closes by 14 Dec**. (Claude Code)

🧳 Kimi K3's teen co-author leaves.

Chen Guangyu, 17, has left Moonshot AI for the Bay Area, and says joining Anthropic is "not happening." (SBS)

⚛️ Dead nuclear plants, new AI customers.

The US is lending **up to $4.4B** to restart three shut reactors, about **2.25 GW** in total. **Microsoft** has a 20-year deal for one; **Google** is backing another, due early 2029. (AP via ABC News)

🗓️ Coming up.

OneDrive + Copilot event 20 Oct. Meta earnings 21 Oct (US). MCPCon in San Jose 22–23 Oct. Infosys results and Nemotron Bolt E4B 23 Oct. Mistral Large 4 weights 27 Oct.

🎯 One thing to try today: audit your AI's plugs

Open the connectors or MCP list in every AI app you use. For each one, ask: **do I still use it, and does it need write access?** Remove the extras. Five minutes, and **your agents can touch less of your life**.

🧠 Pop quiz: 30 seconds, no Googling

1. In MCP, what is a 'server'?

- **A** A GPU cloud
- **B** A small program that offers tools to AI apps
- **C** The chatbot itself

2. How does Schwab plan to let outside AI agents in?

- **A** With your password
- **B** Through read-only MCP servers
- **C** It won't at all

3. How much of Anthropic's stock goes to its new fund to start?

- **A** 1%
- **B** 5%
- **C** 20%

Answers (no peeking): 1. B: you wrap a tool in a server once, and any MCP app can use it · 2. B: agents can check balances and research, but not move money · 3. B: 5% now, plus 2% per 50% rise in value; about 20% counting older pledges

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